



THIRD TRIMESTER CHANGES

The Final Stage of Pregnancy

The third trimester spans weeks 27 to 40 (or beyond) and involves rapid fetal growth and significant physical preparation for labor and delivery.

Body Changes During the Third Trimester

- The uterus expands to just below the ribcage, causing shortness of breath.
- Heartburn and indigestion are common as the stomach is displaced.
- Swelling (edema) of feet, ankles, and hands may occur.
- Sleeping becomes more difficult due to discomfort and frequent urination.
- Braxton Hicks contractions become stronger and more frequent.
- The baby may drop lower in the pelvis (lightening) closer to labor.
- Colostrum (early breast milk) may begin to leak from the breasts.
- Fatigue often returns as physical demands increase.

Fetal Development Highlights

- By week 28, the baby can open and close their eyes.
- By week 32, the baby practices breathing movements.
- By week 36, the baby is considered late preterm.
- By week 40, the baby is considered full term and ready for birth.

Warning Signs

- Sudden severe headache, vision changes, or facial swelling (possible preeclampsia)
- Heavy vaginal bleeding
- Decreased or absent fetal movement
- Signs of preterm labor (regular contractions before week 37)
- Water breaking (rupture of membranes)

Key Takeaway

The third trimester requires close medical monitoring. Birth plans, hospital bag preparation, and understanding labor signs are all important steps during this stage.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

Educational content informed by American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists. (2021). Your pregnancy and childbirth: Month to month (6th ed.). Mayo Clinic. (2023). Fetal development: The third trimester. March of Dimes. (2021). Third trimester: Your body and trimester. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. (2022). Prenatal care.